

LEARNING FROM MOTHER NATURE, THE OLDEST AND THE WISEST

How to make friends among walking people—On becoming a grandmother—The charms of eco-Extremistan—Never small enough—Harvard-Soviet chic

I am writing this essay three years after the completion of *The Black Swan*—which I have kept intact except for a few clarifying footnotes. Since then, I’ve written a dozen “scholarly” papers around some aspects of the Black Swan idea. These are very, very boring to read, since almost all academic papers are made to bore, impress, provide credibility, intimidate even, be presented at meetings, but not to be read except by suckers (or detractors) or, even worse, graduate students. Also, I am making the “what to do next” more salient here—you can take a horse to water and, in addition, you may have to make it drink. So this essay will allow me to go deeper into some points. Like the main text itself, the beginning will be what is called literary, and progressively turn technical.

I owe the idea of this book-length essay to Danny Kahneman, toward whom I (and my ideas) have more debt than toward anyone else on this planet. He convinced me that I had obligations to try to make the horse drink.

ON SLOW BUT LONG WALKS

Over the past three years, my life experienced a bit of change, mostly for the better. Like parties, a book puts you on the envelope of serendipity; it even gets you invited to more parties. During my dark days, I was called a trader in Paris (something extremely *vulgaire*), a philosopher in London (meaning too theoretical), a prophet in New York (dissingly, because of my then false prophecy), and an economist in Jerusalem (something very materialistic). I now saw myself dealing with the stress of having to live up to the wholly undeserved designations of a prophet in Israel (a very, very ambitious project), a *philosophe* in France, an economist in London, and a trader in New York (where it is respectable).

Such exposure brought hate mail, at least one death threat (by former